

div / curl / grad / ∇?
→ Operators (Col 1)

Helix r(t)?
→ FS Chain (Col 1 btm)

Surface area?
→ Monge (Col 2 btm)

∫F·dr or work?
→ Line Int (Col 2–3)

∭ or volume?
→ Triple Int (Col 2)

∮ circulation?
→ Circ (Col 3)

SCOPE · PRIORITY · EXAM ORDER

In scope: triple integrals, cyl/sph setup, curves, helix/FS, surface area, grad/div/curl/Laplacian, line integrals, circulation.

1. Operators2. Helix / FS3. Surface area4. Line integrals5. Triple integrals

Weak-student rule: do not spread effort evenly. Make operator identities, helix template, Monge formula and line-integral workflow nearly automatic first.

CORE OPERATORS · CARTESIAN

$\nabla = 1\partial_x + 1\partial_y + 1\partial_z$
 $\nabla f = (f_x, f_y, f_z)$ → vector output
 $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{F} = \partial_x F_1 + \partial_y F_2 + \partial_z F_3$ → scalar output

$\nabla \times \mathbf{F} = \begin{vmatrix} \mathbf{i} & \mathbf{j} & \mathbf{k} \\ \partial_x & \partial_y & \partial_z \\ F_1 & F_2 & F_3 \end{vmatrix}$ → middle term sign flips

$\nabla^2 f = f_{xx} + f_{yy} + f_{zz}$ → sum all pure 2nd derivs
Always: $\nabla \times (\nabla f) = \mathbf{0}$, $\nabla \cdot (\nabla \times \mathbf{F}) = 0$.

Product rules: $\nabla(uv) = u\nabla v + v\nabla u$, $\nabla \cdot (u\mathbf{F}) = u\nabla \cdot \mathbf{F} + \mathbf{F} \cdot \nabla u$, $\nabla \times (u\mathbf{F}) = \nabla u \times \mathbf{F} + u\nabla \times \mathbf{F}$
Cross-product rule: $\nabla \times (\mathbf{A} \times \mathbf{B}) = \mathbf{A}(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{B}) - \mathbf{B}(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{A}) + (\mathbf{B} \cdot \nabla)\mathbf{A} - (\mathbf{A} \cdot \nabla)\mathbf{B}$

If you see → scalar input: use ∇ or ∇^2 . Vector input: use $\nabla \cdot$ or $\nabla \times$. Check output type matches.

RADIAL IDENTITIES · MUST MEMORIZE

$\mathbf{r} = x\mathbf{i} + y\mathbf{j} + z\mathbf{k}$, $r = |\mathbf{r}| = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2 + z^2}$
 $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{r} = 3$ → instant, $\nabla \times \mathbf{r} = \mathbf{0}$ → instant, $\nabla(r^2) = 2\mathbf{r}$ → instant
 $\nabla(r^n) = nr^{n-2}\mathbf{r} = nr^{n-1}\hat{\mathbf{r}}$, $\nabla(1/r) = -\mathbf{r}/r^3 = -\hat{\mathbf{r}}/r^2$
Radial Laplacian: $\nabla^2 f(r) = f''(r) + \frac{2}{r}f'(r)$ → critical for $\ln r, r^n$ types

If you see $(x^2 + y^2 + z^2)^n$ or $h(r)$ → convert to radial form $r^k \hat{\mathbf{r}}$ FIRST, then apply radial formula.

2024 auto-marks: $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{r} = 3$, $\nabla \times \mathbf{r} = \mathbf{0}$, $\nabla r^2 = 2\mathbf{r}$. Write these instantly.

Common trap: mixing $\mathbf{r}$ and r^2 , or writing scalar when vector is needed → fix: check output type after every computation.

CURVES · ARCLENGTH · HELIX

$\mathbf{r}(t) = (x(t), y(t), z(t))$, $\mathbf{v} = \mathbf{r}'(t)$, $ds = |\mathbf{r}'(t)|dt$, $s(t) = \int_{t_0}^t |\mathbf{r}'(u)| du$

Helix: $\mathbf{r}(t) = (a \cos t, a \sin t, bt)$, $\mathbf{r}' = (-a \sin t, a \cos t, b)$, $|\mathbf{r}'| = c = \sqrt{a^2 + b^2}$ → constant

If you see $\mathbf{r}(t) = (a \cos t, a \sin t, bt)$ → it is a helix. Execute the FS chain below.

Exam sequence: differentiate → speed → arclength → unit tangent → unit normal → binormal → curvature/torsion.

FRENET-SERRET CORE

$\hat{\mathbf{t}} = \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{ds} = \frac{\mathbf{r}'}{|\mathbf{r}'|}$ → normalize first

$\kappa = \left| \frac{d\hat{\mathbf{t}}}{ds} \right|$

$\frac{d\hat{\mathbf{t}}}{ds} = \kappa \hat{\mathbf{n}}$ → then $\hat{\mathbf{n}} = \frac{1}{\kappa} \frac{d\hat{\mathbf{t}}}{ds}$

$\hat{\mathbf{b}} = \hat{\mathbf{t}} \times \hat{\mathbf{n}}$ → cross product order matters

$\frac{d\hat{\mathbf{b}}}{ds} = -\tau \hat{\mathbf{n}}$

Helix results: $\kappa = \frac{a}{a^2 + b^2}$, $\tau = \frac{b}{a^2 + b^2}$, $\Omega = \kappa \hat{\mathbf{b}} + \tau \hat{\mathbf{t}}$

Common trap: computing $d\hat{\mathbf{t}}/ds$ and calling it κ → fix: ALWAYS divide by $|\mathbf{r}'|$ to convert $d\mathbf{r} \rightarrow ds$

CYLINDRICAL / SPHERICAL OPERATORS

Cyl: $\nabla f = f_r \hat{\mathbf{r}} + \frac{1}{r} f_\phi \hat{\boldsymbol{\phi}} + f_z \hat{\mathbf{z}}$
 $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{F} = \frac{1}{r} \partial_r(rF_r) + \frac{1}{r} \partial_\theta F_\theta + \partial_z F_z$ → note $\frac{1}{r} \partial_r(rF_r)$ structure
 $\nabla^2 f = \frac{1}{r} \partial_r(rf_r) + \frac{1}{r^2} f_{\theta\theta} + f_{zz}$

Sph: $\nabla f = f_r \hat{\mathbf{r}} + \frac{1}{r} f_\phi \hat{\boldsymbol{\phi}} + \frac{1}{r \sin \phi} f_\theta \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$
 $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{F} = \frac{1}{r^2} \partial_r(r^2 F_r) + \frac{1}{r \sin \phi} \partial_\phi(\sin \phi F_\phi) + \frac{1}{r \sin \phi} \partial_\theta F_\theta$
 $\nabla^2 f = \frac{1}{r^2} \partial_r(r^2 f_r) + \frac{1}{r^2 \sin \phi} \partial_\phi(\sin \phi f_\phi) + \frac{1}{r^2 \sin^2 \phi} f_{\theta\theta}$ → use if f depends on ϕ or θ

Purely radial $\mathbf{F} = F_r(r)\hat{\mathbf{r}}$: $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{F} = \frac{1}{r^2} \frac{d}{dr}(r^2 F_r)$, $\nabla \times \mathbf{F} = \mathbf{0}$ away from singularities.

If you see $(x^2 + y^2 + z^2)^n(x, y, z)$ → rewrite as $r^{2n+1}\hat{\mathbf{r}}$, identify F_r , use spherical div formula.

Common trap: forgetting $\hat{\mathbf{r}} = \mathbf{r}/r$ introduces extra r → fix: write F_r explicitly before applying formula.

COORDINATES · JACOBIANS · BOUNDS

Polar / Cyl: $x = r \cos \theta$, $y = r \sin \theta$, $dA = r dr d\theta$, $dV = r dr d\theta dz$
Spherical: $x = r \sin \phi \cos \theta$, $y = r \sin \phi \sin \theta$, $z = r \cos \phi$
 $dV = r^2 \sin \phi dr d\phi d\theta$ → never drop $\sin \phi$

First octant $\Rightarrow 0 \leq \theta \leq \pi/2$, $0 \leq \phi \leq \pi/2$
Cone $\mathbf{z} = r \Rightarrow \phi = \pi/4$
Sphere radius $a \Rightarrow r = a$

Offset cylinder $x^2 + (y-1)^2 = 1 \Rightarrow r = 2 \sin \theta$

Setup rule: sketch the shadow region first, then choose coordinates by the geometry trigger table.

TRIPLE-INTEGRAL MICRO-TEMPLATES

Volume: $V(D) = \iiint_D 1 dV$ → integrand is 1, not the surface
Centroid: $\bar{\mathbf{z}} = \frac{1}{V} \iiint_D z dV$ → divide by V at the end

Cartesian: inner variable runs from lower surface to upper surface. → sketch region first
Cylindrical: sidewall → r bound. Floor → z lower. Roof → z upper. θ from geometry. Attach Jacobian r .
Spherical: sphere → r bound. Cone → ϕ bound. Octant → θ bound. Attach $r^2 \sin \phi$.

If you see $\iiint$ → sketch solid, pick coordinates by geometry, write bounds, attach Jacobian.

EP2 Q11 pattern: sidewall $r = 2 \sin \theta$, floor $z = 0$, roof $z = r$, $dV = r dz dr d\theta$

Common trap: writing $dV = dr d\theta dz$ without Jacobian → fix: cyl → r , sph → $r^2 \sin \phi$

SURFACE PARAMETRIZATION · AREA

Parametric surface: $\mathbf{X}(u, v)$
 $dS = |\mathbf{X}_u \times \mathbf{X}_v| du dv$
Graph surface: $z = f(x, y)$
 $\mathbf{X}(x, y) = (x, y, f(x, y))$
 $dS = \sqrt{1 + f_x^2 + f_y^2} dx dy$ → do not forget the $\sqrt{}$

Always find the projection region in the xy -plane before integrating. → sketch region

Paraboloid cap template: solve intersection first. If $z = 2 - r^2$ and cone $z = r$, then $2 - r^2 = r \Rightarrow r = 1$
Then $A = \int_0^{2\pi} \int_0^1 \sqrt{1 + 4r^2} r dr d\theta$

If you see "find the area of $z = f(x, y)$ " → Monge formula: $\sqrt{1 + f_x^2 + f_y^2}$, project onto xy -plane.

Common trap: using the bounding surface's derivatives instead of the named surface → fix: check which surface the question asks for.

COMMON SURFACE-AREA PATTERNS

Problem type	Minimal skeleton
Graph $z = f(x, y)$	$f_x, f_y \rightarrow \sqrt{1 + f_x^2 + f_y^2} \rightarrow$ project region → polar if circular
Sphere	parameterize by angles $\rightarrow \mathbf{X}_u \times \mathbf{X}_v$
Paraboloid above cone	solve intersection in r first, then Monge formula on paraboloid

LINE INTEGRALS · DIRECT METHOD

$\int_C \mathbf{F} \cdot d\mathbf{r} = \int_a^b \mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t)) \cdot \mathbf{r}'(t) dt$ → substitute path into $\mathbf{F}$ first
In 2D: $\int_C P dx + Q dy$
Workflow: parameterize $C \rightarrow$ compute $d\mathbf{r} \rightarrow$ write $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t))$ explicitly $\rightarrow$ dot $\rightarrow$ integrate.

LINE-INTEGRAL PATTERNS TO DRILL

Type	Minimal symbolic template
Straight segment	$\mathbf{r}(t) = \mathbf{A} + t(\mathbf{B} - \mathbf{A})$, $0 \leq t \leq 1$
Circle	$\mathbf{r}(t) = (a \cos t, a \sin t)$ or 3D variant
Helix	$\mathbf{r}(t) = (a \cos t, a \sin t, t)$, $\mathbf{r}' = (-\sin t, \cos t, 1)$
Broken path	split $C = C_1 \cup C_2 \cup \dots$, integrate each, sum
Path in 2D	substitute $y = y(x)$, $dy = y'(x)dx$, single-variable integral

2023 MT2 pattern: compute work on a helix, then on a straight segment between the same endpoints and compare. → values will differ

CIRCULATION TEMPLATE · §4.4

Circulation = $\oint_C \mathbf{F} \cdot d\mathbf{r}$ net tangential component of $\mathbf{F}$ around a closed curve. → CCW = positive

Step 1. Parameterize: circle radius $a \rightarrow \mathbf{r}(t) = (a \cos t, a \sin t)$, $0 \leq t \leq 2\pi$ → CCW

Step 2. $\mathbf{r}'(t) = (-a \sin t, a \cos t)$

Step 3. Substitute: $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t)) \cdot \mathbf{r}'(t)$ → simplify → integrate over $[0, 2\pi]$.

If you see $\oint$ or "circulation" → parameterize closed curve (CCW), compute $\mathbf{r}'$, substitute $\mathbf{F}$, dot, integrate.

Common trap: wrong orientation reverses sign → fix: confirm CCW. Reversing direction flips the answer.

TOP 10 EXAM-READY DRILLS

#	Source	Why it matters
1	2025 MT2 Q2(a)–(b)	Best complete radial-field divergence/curl drill
2	2024 MT2 Q1(a)–(c)	Fast operator identities, nearly automatic marks
3	Tutorial 7 Q1(a)–(c)	Derive radial-gradient identities, not just memorize
4	2022 MT2 Q1(b)	Best Frenet-Serret frame drill
5	2025 MT2 Q1	Best graph-surface area exam problem
6	2023 MT2 Q2(a)	Best 3D direct line-integral drill
7	2023 MT2 Q1(c)	Radial divergence with parameter condition
8	Tutorial 7 Q2	Training version of paraboloid-area setup
9	2022 MT2 Q1(c)	Curvature and torsion follow-up after frame mastery
10	Extra Problems 2 Q11(a)	Best cylindrical triple-integral setup drill

COMMON BOUND / GEOMETRY TRIGGERS

Given geometry	Immediate move
$x^2 + y^2$ everywhere	Switch to polar/cylindrical
$x^2 + y^2 + z^2$ or sphere/cone	Test spherical first
Graph $z = f(x, y)$	Project onto xy -plane, use Monge
Patch inside cylinder	Cylinder defines boundary disk only
Offset circle/cylinder	Rewrite in polar: $\mathbf{r} =$ function of θ
First octant	All coords ≥ 0 , angle bounds shrink
Helix	Use parametric $\hat{\mathbf{t}}$, speed is constant

COMMON MISTAKES TO ELIMINATE

Operators: writing scalar where vector is required, or vice versa. → check output type

Radial questions: failing to rewrite field in radial form before differentiating. → convert first

Frenet-Serret: using d/dt as if it were d/ds . → divide by $|\mathbf{r}'|$

Surface area: forgetting projection region or using wrong surface's derivatives. → name the surface

Triple integrals: missing Jacobian r or $r^2 \sin \phi$ → write Jacobian immediately

Line integrals: not substituting both path and differential. → write $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t))$ first

Circulation: wrong orientation reverses sign. → confirm CCW

Exam habit: before integrating, say silently: formula, bounds, Jacobian, orientation, variable order.

FOLLOW BLINDLY PIPELINES

Line Integral: 1. Parameterize C . 2. Compute $d\mathbf{r}$. 3. Substitute $\mathbf{F}(\mathbf{r}(t))$. 4. Dot and integrate.

Surface Area: 1. Write dS . 2. Choose graph or parametrization. 3. Project region. 4. Integrate.

Triple Integral: 1. Sketch solid. 2. Choose coordinates. 3. Write bounds. 4. Attach Jacobian and integrate.

